GAME DECONSTRUCTION · MID-CORE TOWER DEFENSE

Raid Rush: Tower Defense TD

Panteon (Ankara) · iOS and Android · live since 2023 · Strategy / tower defense with card-drafting and merge progression.

#4
tower defense game by US revenue, Q2 2025 (Sensor Tower)

~$220K
a week in the US alone, Q2 2025 (Sensor Tower estimate)

61K → 85.5K
US active users across Q2 2025 while most genre peers shrank

The one-paragraph read

Raid Rush takes the most familiar genre on mobile, tower defense, and adds one idea: **you build the road as well as the towers**. Each level-up in a battle offers three random cards (towers or path pieces), so every run is a small drafting puzzle. That hook is cheap to understand in an ad and deep enough to hold strategy players. Around it sits a classic mid-core engine: a deck of 6 towers, 2 skills and a hero, a 12-step rarity ladder climbed by merging duplicates, and a dense live-ops calendar (clan wars, boss brawls, two-week Elite League seasons, a two-month card album, licensed collaborations such as *Terminator 2*). I chose it because it is the kind of game I want to work on: a live game where systems, balance and events all have to hold together.

Three things I take away

1. A readable hook, a deep tail. The path-building draft is explainable in one sentence, but the merge ladder now reaches level 150 (Eternal tier, added in 2026), so the game's depth for spenders keeps growing without changing the core.

2. Social layers carry the late game. Since January 2026 both Clan War and Boss Brawl run on the same 3-day prep, 6-day attack rhythm and pay the same permanent Clan Coins, which ties long-term progression to a team.

3. The risk is the randomness. The draft that makes each run fresh is also the top source of complaints ("ten rounds without a tower card"). My proposals on page 6 target that tension without removing the luck.

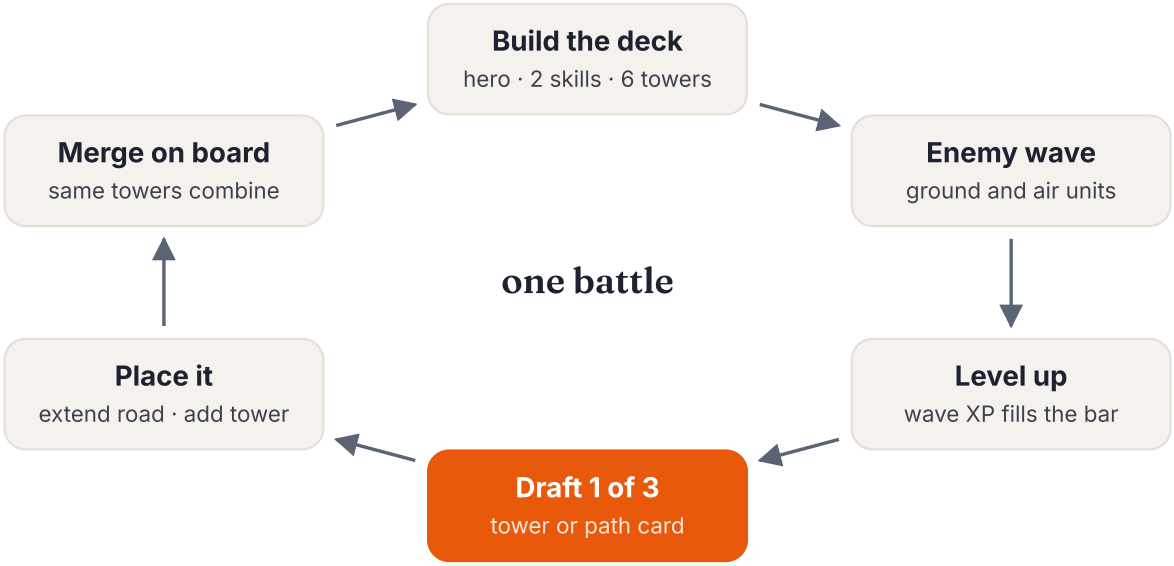
Inside

1	**Core loop**	The drafting puzzle inside each battle, and the modes built on it
2	**Meta and progression**	Deck structure, the 12-tier merge ladder, what feeds each progression path
3	**Economy and monetisation**	Price points, subscriptions, gacha with pity, sources and sinks
4	**Live ops and retention**	Event rhythms, the clan layer, the 2026 update pattern, D1–D90 hypotheses
5	**Proposals**	Three changes, each with a hypothesis, an A/B test and guardrails

Method. Desk research from public sources only: store listings, the developer's own patch notes, blog and guides, Sensor Tower estimates, community guides and player reviews. I have no internal data, so every statement about KPIs is a hypothesis, marked as such. Sources are listed on the last page. Written September 2026.

1 · CORE LOOP

A drafting puzzle inside a tower defense



In-battle loop, reconstructed from the store description, official guides and gameplay footage. Gem-paid refreshes of the three offered cards and revives are optional exits from this loop.

Why the core works

- **Two decisions per pick.** "Which card" and "where" are separate choices: a path piece lengthens the route, which buys time for every tower already on it.
- **Luck the player can steer.** The deck limits what can appear (6 towers from 4 categories: Elemental, Utility, Vanguard, Swift), so the draft is random but never arbitrary.
- **Visible power spikes.** Merging on the board and hero skills give the "screen-clearing" moments that ads are made of.

What the layers ask of the player

LAYER	SKILL TESTED
Deck building	Coverage: one heavy single-target tower for bosses, one anti-air answer for swarms
Draft	Reading the next waves; tower now or road now
Placement	Choke points and overlapping ranges
Meta	Which tower to invest scarce blueprints and gold in

Modes: the same core, re-framed

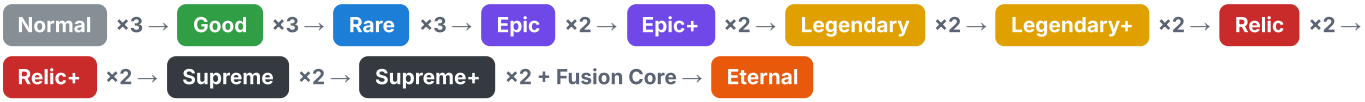
MODE	WHAT CHANGES	DESIGN JOB
Campaign (110 chapters)	New maps and enemies; 10 chapters added in Aug 2026	Main progression, content drip
Epic chapters	Harder versions, better rewards	Resource farm for invested players
Elite League	Opens at chapter 70; 2-week seasons, 1 buff + 3 debuffs per season	Competitive endgame; modifiers keep old decks from solving it
Speed Run	2x speed, rarity caps on cards, permanent best times	Skill expression without spending advantage
Boss Brawl / Clan War	Clan-based, 3-day prep + 6-day attack	Social retention (page 5)

One deck, many ways to make it stronger



A battle deck: 1 hero (from account level 7), 2 skills and 6 towers, plus Core Parts in Primary and Utility slots. Clan War allows up to 4 decks per player, and no card may appear in two of them: a rule that turns collection breadth into value.

The rarity ladder (merge identical cards to climb)



Lower tiers need three identical copies, higher tiers two, so early progress is fast and generous and late progress is slow and precious. Card levels cap at 100 up to Supreme, then 110 at Supreme+ and 150 at Eternal. Jokers stand in for missing duplicates, and since 2026 unwanted high-tier cards can be salvaged for Chips or Nano Cubes, so no pull is ever fully wasted.

Progression vectors and what feeds them

VECTOR	RESOURCE	MAIN SOURCES
Tower and skill level	Gold + blueprints	Battles, chests, quests
Tower and skill rarity	Duplicate cards, Jokers	Chests (gacha), events, Spark Shop, exchanges
Beyond level 110 / Eternal	Nano Cube, Fusion Core	Elite Shop (Elite Coins from league rank), salvage
Heroes	Hero upgrades, event currency	Hero Pass, Spinfinity and flash hero events
Core Parts	Parts of each rarity	Core Part chests; 3 of a rarity trade for 1 Joker part
Team progress	Clan Coins (permanent)	Clan War, Boss Brawl; spent in the Clan Shop

Design read. The ladder is built for a very long tail: each new tier (Supreme+, Eternal) extends the ceiling for the most invested players without touching what a new player sees. The cost is complexity: about ten currencies and materials is a lot to read, and every new system needs its own onboarding. A question I would ask the team: what share of mid-game churn happens right after a new currency is introduced?

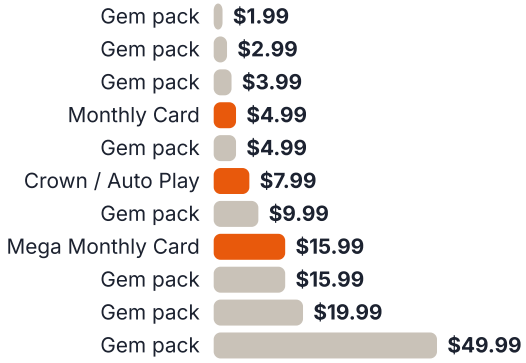
Where Raid Rush sits in its genre

MODEL	EXAMPLE	WHERE THE RANDOMNESS IS	WHAT THE PLAYER CONTROLS
Classic tower defense	Kingdom Rush	None: fixed paths, fixed build spots	Tower choice and upgrades
Random merge defense	Rush Royale	Which unit appears on a fixed grid	When to summon and what to merge; PvP duels
Drafted road and towers	**Raid Rush**	Which 3 cards are offered at each level-up	The road itself, placement, and the deck behind the draft

The drafted road is the differentiator: players shape the map instead of only reacting to it, which is also why every run looks different in a video ad.

Three wallets: time, luck and status

US App Store price points



From the public App Store listing (Sept 2026). Subscriptions in orange (Golden Crown and Auto Play are weekly). Pack names on the store are generic, so gem amounts are not shown.

Where money meets the design

- **Subscriptions for daily players.** Monthly Card: 500 gems up front + 150 a day, plus speed-up and offline-earning perks. Mega Monthly: 1,200 + 300 a day. Claimed for 30 days that is about **1,000 gems per dollar** vs about **640**, so the Mega card must sell on its other perks.
- **Gacha with pity.** Limited chests such as the Retro Special Chest guarantee a Legendary card of your choice every 60 opens; shop chests now level up (to 5) as you open them, improving the odds.
- **Spend-triggered events.** The weekly Spend & Earn event rewards any purchase anywhere; 5-minute Flash Events discount upgrades or currencies.
- **Paid convenience.** Weekly Auto Play and Golden Crown (Elite League perks such as crown protection) sell time and safety, not raw power.
- **Ads.** Players report interstitials after the early game that stop once a purchase is made: a classic "first purchase removes friction" funnel. Rewarded ads cover revives and extras.

Sources and sinks (simplified)

CURRENCY	EARNED FROM	SPENT ON	PRESSURE POINT
Gold	Battles, chests	Levelling cards	Grows with card level: the main grind
Gems (premium)	Purchases, cards, events	Chests, hero events, refreshes, revives	Guides tell players never to spend gems on refreshes: players see those as poor value
Clan Coins	Clan War, Boss Brawl	Clan Shop (daily and weekly)	Permanent, so no "use it or lose it" stress
Elite Coins	Elite League rank	Nano Cube, Fusion Core	Endgame materials gated behind skill rank
Spark	Duplicate album cards	Spark Shop chests	Turns album duplicates into value

Spend is layered by player type

Small, regular
Monthly Card at $4.99: gems every day for a month, and a reason to log in daily to claim them

Mid
Battle Pass, Hero Pass, weekly Auto Play and Golden Crown: pay for time, convenience and safety

Deep
Limited chests into a 12-tier ladder capped at level 150; Spend & Earn rewards every purchase

Design read. Each layer has its own ceiling, so a player who never spends more than $5 a month still gets value that feels good. The competitive modes are shielded in two different ways: Speed Run caps rarities outright, and Elite League rotates modifiers each season so no single maxed deck solves it for long.

Several clocks running at once



Known durations from Panteon's patch notes, laid over the same 8 weeks. How often Clan War and Boss Brawl recur is not public, so one cycle of each is shown. The overlap is the point: on almost any day, some clock is about to end.

How the social layer is built

- **Clan War:** 5 clans per match; each player registers up to 4 decks; a clan needs at least 10 members to lock decks. Each deck attacks once a day (reset 00:00 UTC); the clan with the most castle HP left wins; rewards follow each player's damage.
- **Daily repair missions** give low-power members a way to help: contribution is not only about deck strength.
- **Album trading:** card requests to clanmates every 48 hours, a proven "reason to talk to your team" from casual games.
- **Licensed collabs** (Terminator 2, second run) bring back lapsed players and create ad hooks. Collab heroes stay usable afterwards but stop upgrading: fair to buyers, while keeping the next collab special.

Retention hypotheses

	LIKELY DRIVER
D1	The path-building hook; fast early merges (×3 tiers are generous); first chest unlocks
D7	Hero unlocked at account level 7; daily quests; first clan; first album sets
D30	Clan obligations (repair, attacks); Elite League from chapter 70; album grand prize; monthly card value
D90+	Rarity ceiling (Eternal), seasonal modifiers, collabs, new chapters every few months

Hypotheses, not measured data. The Q2 2025 rise in US active users (61K to 85.5K) fits a game whose late-game systems keep players.

2026 in patch notes: what the studio chose to build

UPDATE	HEADLINE	PILLAR IT SERVES
1.460 · Jan	Clan War; Boss Brawl moved onto the same schedule; Clan Coins; chapters to 100	Social, simplification
1.470 · Apr	Two-month Album with clan card requests; new special towers; balance pass	Social, collection
1.480 · Jun	Elite League seasons with modifiers; Speed Run; Supreme+ and Eternal tiers; salvage	Endgame depth
1.490 · Jul	10 more Boss Brawl chapters; newsletter sign-up bonus	Content, re-engagement
1.495 · Aug	Elite League from chapter 70; levelling shop chests; weekly Spend & Earn; chapters 101–110	Access, monetisation
Sept	Terminator 2 returns (Sept 16 – Oct 13)	Reactivation, UA

Design read. About one major update every one to two months, alternating social, endgame and monetisation work. January is the one to study: Boss Brawl cut from 50 to 30 chapters and moved onto the Clan War schedule, two currencies merged into one permanent Clan Coin. Fewer systems that reinforce each other beat more systems; this studio is willing to simplify.

5 · PAIN POINTS AND PROPOSALS

Where players push back, and what I would test

WHAT PLAYERS SAY (STORE REVIEWS)	MY READING
"Many rounds without a single tower card", mostly path or land pieces in late waves	Draft variance is too high at the moment it hurts most
Walls where "bosses one-shot the base"; talk of pay-to-win	Losses do not explain themselves, so players blame money, not strategy
Praise: no forced energy, fair ad load, a team that "actually listens" and reverts bad changes	Trust is an asset worth protecting in any fix

PROPOSAL 1 Draft protection that keeps the luck

If the last 3 level-up offers contained no tower card, the next offer guarantees at least one tower from the deck. Path pieces are weighted down once the road is already long. The draft stays random; only the worst streaks are removed (the same idea as the pity counter Raid Rush already uses in chests).

Hypothesis	Fewer draft-streak losses raise chapter completion at known walls without hurting revenue.
Test	50/50 A/B on players reaching chapter 15, for 2 weeks.
Primary	Completion rate of wall chapters; D7 and D14 retention of the cohort.
Guardrails	Gem spend on refreshes and ARPDAU: ship only if the retention gain outweighs any refresh revenue lost.

PROPOSAL 2 A loss screen that teaches

After a loss, show where the base was breached (wave, air or ground, enemy type) and suggest one tower from the player's own collection that counters it, with a one-tap swap into the deck. It backs up the developer's promise that every level can be beaten for free.

Hypothesis	Explaining losses turns "pay to win" into "learn to win": more retries, fewer quits after losing.
Test	A/B on all players from account level 7 (when heroes open); 2 weeks.
Primary	Retry within 10 minutes of a loss; 24-hour churn after 3 losses in a row.
Guardrails	Store conversion on the loss screen; session length.

PROPOSAL 3 A way into Clan War for small clans

A clan needs 10 members to lock decks, so small or new clans sit out the biggest social event. Let clans of 5–9 join with "allied decks": standard decks at the clan's median power, scoring less damage, so they can take part without an advantage.

Hypothesis	Taking part in a first Clan War raises D30 retention for members of small clans.
Test	Split small clans by clan ID; 2 Clan War cycles.
Primary	Participation rate and D30 of small-clan members; clan growth to 10+.
Guardrails	Win-rate fairness for full clans; matchmaking time.

Sources

1. Raid Rush official blog (raidrush.com/en/blog): update notes 1.460 (Jan 2026), 1.470 (Apr 2026), 1.480 (Jun 2026), 1.490 (Jul 2026), 1.495 (Aug 2026); Clan War guide; Terminator 2 event; merge-system guide.
2. Apple App Store and Google Play listings for Raid Rush: Tower Defense TD (description, in-app purchase prices), Sept 2026.
3. Sensor Tower blog: Top 5 tower defense games by revenue, US, Q4 2024 and Q2 2025.
4. Player reviews aggregated on JustUseApp; community guide on GrindnStrat (deck basics, rarity names, gem advice).